

MATTHEW | GALATIANS | EZRA

SEP - NOV 2026



ACTS 2 DEVOTIONS

Hymn of the Month

SEPTEMBER

What a Friend We Have in Jesus

What a friend we have in Jesus,
All our sins and griefs to bear!
What a privilege to carry
Everything to God in prayer!
O what peace we often forfeit,
O what needless pain we bear,
All because we do not carry
Everything to God in prayer!

Have we trials and temptations?
Is there trouble anywhere?
We should never be discouraged;
Take it to the Lord in prayer!
Can we find a friend so faithful
Who will all our sorrows share?
Jesus knows our every weakness;
Take it to the Lord in prayer!

Are we weak and heavy laden,
Cumbered with a load of care?
Precious Savior, still our refuge--
Take it to the Lord in prayer!
Do your friends despise, forsake you?
Take it to the Lord in prayer!
In his arms he'll take and shield you;
you will find a solace there.

*Author: Joseph Medlicott Scriven
Composer: Charles C. Converse*

OCTOBER

Be Still My Soul

Be still, my soul! The Lord is on your side;
Bear patiently the cross of grief or pain;
Leave to your God to order and provide;
In every change, He faithful will remain.
Be still, my soul! Your best, your heavenly Friend
Through thorny ways leads to a joyful end.

Be still, my soul! Your God doth undertake
To guide the future as He has the past;
Your hope, your confidence let nothing shake;
All now mysterious shall be bright at last.
Be still, my soul! The waves and winds still know
His voice who ruled them while He dwelt below.

Be still, my soul! Though dearest friends depart
And all is darkened in the vale of tears;
Then shall you better know His love, His heart,
Who comes to soothe your sorrows and your fears.
Be still, my soul! Your Jesus can repay
From His own fullness all He takes away.

Be still, my soul! The hour is hastening on
When we shall be forever with the Lord,
When disappointment, grief, and fear are gone,
Sorrow forgot, love's purest joys restored.
Be still, my soul! When change and tears are past,
All safe and blessed we shall meet at last.

*Author: Kathrina von Schlegel
Translator: Jane Borthwick
Composer: Jean Sibelius*

Hymn of the Month

NOVEMBER

This Is My Father's World

This is my Father's world, and to my listening ears
All nature sings, and round me rings,
The music of the spheres.
This is my Father's world: I rest me in the thought
Of rocks and trees, of skies and seas –
His hand the wonders wrought.

This is my Father's world, the birds their carols raise,
The morning light, the lily white,
Declare their maker's praise.
This is my Father's world: He shines in all that's fair;
In the rustling grass I hear Him pass;
He speaks to me everywhere.

This is my Father's world, O let me ne'er forget
That though the wrong seems oft so strong,
God is the ruler yet.
This is my Father's world: the battle is not done;
Jesus who died shall be satisfied
And earth and heaven be one.

This is my Father's world, should my heart be ever sad?
The Lord is King, let the heavens ring.
God reigns, let the earth be glad.
This is my Father's world: now closer to Heaven bound,
For dear to God is the earth Christ trod
No place but is holy ground.

This is my Father's world, I walk a desert lone
In a bush ablaze to my wondering gaze
God makes His glory known.
This is my Father's world: a wanderer I may roam
Whate'er my lot, it matters not,
My heart is still at home.

Author: Maltbie D. Babcock

Composer: Unknown

Arranger: Franklin L. Sheppard

Scripture Memory

On Fridays we will spend time memorizing the chapter or passage of the month.

September	Psalm 16
October	Psalm 23
November	Psalm 32
December	Isaiah 9:1-7
January	Psalm 37:1-9

Bible Text: Matthew 1 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 1:1-17

“‘Christ’ is roughly the Greek equivalent to ‘Messiah’ or ‘Anointed’ (see comment on Mk 8:29). ... But Matthew’s linking of ‘Christ’ and ‘son of David’ leaves no doubt of what he is claiming for Jesus.”¹

- What is the significance of Jesus being called “Christ, the son of David”?

[T]he whole genealogy ... names five women: Tamar, Rahab, Ruth, 'the wife of Uriah,' and Mary. Since ancestry and inheritance were traced through the father's line, reference to women in a genealogy was uncommon, but not unheard of. [...] Matthew is interested in affirming that the plan of God has often been fulfilled in history in unanticipated and 'irregular' ways, as was the case in the birth of Jesus from Mary, and through women who took initiative, like Tamar and Ruth."²

- What is the history of these women, and what is the significance of these Gentile women being included in the genealogy of Jesus Christ?

Matthew 1:18-25

- What can we learn about Joseph through this passage? What aspect of his character most challenges me?
- What is the relationship between the meaning of the name “Jesus” and “Immanuel”? What does this reveal about the nature of salvation and Christian living?

1. Kenneth L. Barker and John R. Kohlenberger III, *Zondervan NIV Bible Commentary CD* (Zondervan, 1994), notes on Matthew 1.

1. Kenneth E. Barker and John R. Rommenberger II, *Zondervan NIV Bible* (Zondervan, 1994), 123.
2. *The New Interpreter's Bible: Volume VIII* (Abingdon Press, 1994), 123.

Monday, August 31, 2026

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 25 horizontal dotted lines.

Bible Text: Matthew 2 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 2:1-12

- What might have driven the Magi, despite their limited knowledge, to seek Jesus? What lessons are there about spiritual seeking?
- Why would Herod be “troubled” upon hearing the news of Jesus’ birth, and are there ways I can resonate with his response?
- Why is it significant that the chief priests and the teachers of the law knew where the Messiah was to be born yet did not seek him out?

Matthew 2:13-23

- Consider the hardships Joseph and Mary faced. What lessons can I learn about a life of participating in God's will?

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 25 horizontal dotted lines.

Bible Text: Matthew 3 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 3:1-3

“As a road must be cleared of obstacles before an approaching king, John is calling for the people to clear the obstacles out of their lives that might hinder their reception of the Lord.”³

- Why is repentance necessary in order to receive the kingdom of heaven, and in what ways do I need to “prepare the way of the Lord, make his paths straight”?

Matthew 3:4-6

“John’s diet causes him to stand out as one who has rejected the luxuries of life. His diet and clothing combine with his message to cast a powerful demand for repentance in the light of the nearness of the kingdom. He embodies in his lifestyle the message of repentance he preaches.”⁴

- What can I learn from John about the relationship between one’s lifestyle and the strength of Christian witness?

Matthew 3:13-15

“Why did Jesus ask to be baptized? It was not for repentance for because Jesus never sinned. ‘To fulfill all righteousness’ means to accomplish God’s mission. Jesus saw his baptism as advancing God’s work. Jesus was baptized because (1) he was confessing sin on behalf of the nation, as Nehemiah, Ezra, Moses, and Daniel had done; (2) he was showing support for what John was doing; (3) he was inaugurating his public ministry; (4) he was identifying with the penitent people of God, not with the critical Pharisees who were only watching. Jesus, the perfect man, didn’t need baptism for sin, but he accepted baptism in obedient service to the Father, and God showed his approval.”⁵

- What does baptism symbolize and what does it reveal about how far Jesus goes to be our Immanuel?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

3. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004), 132.
4. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004), 134.
5. *Life Application Study Bible* (Tyndale House Publishers; Zondervan, 1991), 1647.

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Bible Text: Matthew 4 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 4:1-11

- Reflect on the three temptations. What can I learn from Jesus' response to each of these temptations?

Matthew 4:15-17

- How has Jesus' coming fulfilled the prophecy in Isaiah 9:2, "the people dwelling in darkness have seen a great light, and for those dwelling in the region and shadow of death, on them a light has dawned"? How have I experienced this in my life?

Matthew 4:18-22

- What do Jesus' invitation and the response of his first disciples teach me about true discipleship?

Matthew 4:23-25

- What is the commonality among those who came to Jesus? What does it take to come to Jesus, and what does this reveal about true blessing (cf. Matthew 5:3)?

Thursday, September 3, 2026

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 25 horizontal dotted lines.

Friday, September 4, 2026

Scripture Memory: Psalm 16

Please feel free to use the space below to review and memorize the passage.

Bible Text: Matthew 5 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 5:1-12

“More than simply a formal literary introduction, the Beatitudes summarize the essence of the sermon’s message, giving in a nutshell the way in which the kingdom makes its impact on the lives of those who respond to it.... Thus the Beatitudes outline an upside-down reality, or — more precisely — they define reality in such a way that the usual order of things is seen to be upside down in the eyes of God.”⁶

- Notice the progression in the qualities of a blessed person. In what ways have I personally experienced or witnessed the paradoxical truths of a blessed life?

Matthew 5:13-16

- What are the shared characteristics of salt and light and their effect on their surroundings, and what lessons are there about the significance of Jesus’ words, “You are the salt of the earth” and “You are the light of the world”?

Matthew 5:21-30

- What is God’s view towards the sins of the heart, and how does this challenge my attitude towards external vs. internal sins?

Matthew 5:33-48

- What challenging or radical actions does Jesus call for? What view of myself, others, evil, and God is needed in order to live out these exhortations?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

6. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004), 190–203.

Bible Text: Matthew 6 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 6:1-13

- In what ways can I grow in my awareness of the gaze of God, the “Father who sees in secret”?

Matthew 6:5-13

- How does addressing God as “Father” affect my view of prayer and how I relate to God?
- What does Jesus’ instruction to pray for God’s “will to be done, on earth as it is in heaven” reveal about our world? What can I learn about my role in advancing God’s will through prayer?

Matthew 6:19-34

- What is the relationship between worries and storing up treasures in heaven?
- How am I challenged regarding what my eyes are full of and focusing on?
- Why would it be impossible to serve both God and money?

Tuesday, September 8, 2026

Handwriting practice area consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Bible Text: Matthew 7 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 7:1-5

“When the disciple removes the plank of self-righteousness, she is then able to see with eyes of humility the speck that other brothers and sisters may have. A mark of the discipleship community is the responsibility that disciples have to help each other remove the ‘speck’ of sin from each other’s lives, but it must come from a humble and self-examined life that has removed the plank of self-righteous judgment. Then restoration can occur with the right attitude: ‘after self-criticism takes place, relationships are based on redemptive empathy rather than condemning detachment.’”⁷

- Consider whether there is a “speck” I am quick to point out in other people, and a “log” I have not paid attention to in myself.

Matthew 7:7-11

“A first step toward a less naïve understanding of the verses can be made when we observe how Matthew has appropriated them. This little section concludes the long string of imperatives that constitute the core of the Sermon on the Mount from 5:21 to 7:6. We have been asked to forgo anger and retaliation, to love our enemies and forgive those who have injured us, and to control our criticism of others. How can we fulfill all these demands and manifest the higher righteousness of the kingdom? These verses remind us that for us this is impossible, but with God all things are possible. That is, only by persistently asking, seeking and knocking at heaven’s door through prayer will we find grace to obey these impossible demands. Solely through tenacious dependence on God’s graciousness can we deal graciously with those who provoke a negative reaction in us.”⁸

- What does Jesus’ exhortation to “ask,” “seek” and “knock” towards the end of the Sermon on the Mount reveal about what good gifts I should be asking my Heavenly Father for?

Matthew 7:21-23

- What would cause some people to say to Jesus, “Lord, Lord” but not do the “will of my Father who is in heaven”?

Matthew 7:24-27

- Reflect on the fact that the foundation of a house is not visible from the outside. What lessons can I learn about spiritual life from this fact, and what can I do to solidify my foundation?

7. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004), 310.
8. R.A. Hare Douglas, *Interpretation: A Bible Commentary for Teaching and Preaching* (John Knox Press, 1993), 78.

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Wednesday, September 9, 2026

Bible Text: Matthew 8 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 8:2-4

- What can I learn about Jesus from the fact that he “stretched out his hand and touched” the leper?

Matthew 8:5-12

- What can I learn about the centurion’s view of himself and his view of Jesus’ authority?

Matthew 8:21-22

“Most likely the problem was that his father was still quite alive. Jews understood the command to honor father and mother to mean caring for their elderly parents and giving them a proper burial. Apparently, this man had not yet put his commitment to Christ above these cultural expectations.”⁹

- Are there “cultural expectations” or other obligations in my life that I regard as absolute, as if they are on the same plane as my responsibility before God? What specific social demands hinder me from placing my highest priority on following Jesus?

Matthew 8:23-27

- What can I learn from this passage about the relationship between following Jesus and experiencing life’s “storms”?

Matthew 8:32-34

“This response is a sad commentary on the perversion of their values, for one would think they would rejoice at a victory over Satan’s demons. But as one commentator states, ‘all down the ages the world has been refusing Jesus because it prefers the pigs.’”¹⁰

“Here is human selfishness at its worst. It did not matter to these people that two men had been given back their reason; all that mattered to them was that their pigs had perished. It is so often the case that people in effect say, ‘I don’t care what happens to anyone else, if my profits and my comfort and my ease are preserved.’ We may be amazed at the callousness of these people of Gadara, but we must have a care that we too do not resent any helping of others which reduces our own privileges.”¹¹

- What are the “pigs” for which people of this world reject Jesus? In what ways are people in our society today like the townspeople -- more concerned about profit than about human life?

.....

.....

.....

.....

9. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004), 337–61.

10. Ibid.

11. William Barclay, *The Gospel of Matthew: Volume 1* (The Westminster Press, 1975), 323.

Thursday, September 10, 2026

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Thursday, September 10, 2026

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Scripture Memory: Psalm 16

Please feel free to use the space below to review and memorize the passage.

Bible Text: Matthew 9 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 9:1-8

- What was required for the paralytic to be brought to Jesus?
- Whose faith did Jesus see, and how does this challenge me regarding the “paralytics” around me that I need to bring to Jesus?

Matthew 9:14-17

- What do Jesus’ illustrations say about fitting him into the existing framework of one’s life?

Matthew 9:18-22

- What did Jairus (a synagogue ruler) and the woman have to overcome in order to come to Jesus?
- What can I learn about the heart of Jesus from the fact that he took notice of this woman and spoke to her?

Matthew 9:36-37

“The disciples are to ‘ask the Lord of the harvest ... to send out workers into his harvest field.’ The ‘Lord of the harvest’ is God, who will respond to their prayer for harvest workers. But dramatically it is Jesus who steps forward in answer to their prayers to commission the Twelve to go out and minister. The harvest mission includes the immediate assignment of the Twelve to take the gospel message only to Israel (10:1–15), but also the long-range mission of the disciples throughout the world until the Son of Man returns (10:16–23).”¹²

- What can I do to share Jesus’ perspective toward the “crowds” in my life, and imitate his heart of compassion for them?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

12. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004), 337–410.

Monday, September 14, 2026

-26- AUGUST - NOVEMBER 2026 • ACTS2 NETWORK DEVOTIONALS

Bible Text: Matthew 10 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 10:1-15, 40-43

- Reflect on the ennobling of the disciples as they were now given the same ministry that Jesus was regularly conducting. How should this impact my view of myself as a disciple of Jesus, given that I have been entrusted with the same ministry?

Matthew 10:9-10

- How might the disciples have felt upon hearing Jesus' command to take nothing for the journey, and how can I develop a pattern of trusting in God's provisions for my Christian journey?

Matthew 10:16

- What is the picture of Christian life depicted by this verse? How would someone live, who understood Christian life along these terms?

Matthew 10:28-33

- What are the different kinds of fears listed in this passage? What is the relationship between the fear of “him who can destroy both soul and body in hell” and the rest of the fears in this text?

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Bible Text: Matthew 11 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 11:1-6

“He was not turning out to be the kind of Messiah the people had expected. The one to whom he had pointed, the one who would come in blessing and judgment (3:11-12), had brought healing to many but, it would seem, judgment to none—not even to those who had immorally and unlawfully confined the Baptist in a cruel prison...”¹³

- What are some ways in which difficult personal circumstances can cause me to “be offended” at Jesus?

Matthew 11:7-15

“John is a transitional figure who has prepared the way for the Coming One, but Jesus implies here that John will not live to see the full arrival of the kingdom. Jesus’ institution of the new covenant in his blood is a dividing line. The complex of events including the cross, resurrection, ascension, and sending of the Spirit at Pentecost brings the arrival of the kingdom’s redemptive life, by which time John was executed.”¹⁴

- Meditate on the fact that, as a New Testament Christian, I am far more privileged than even John the Baptist.

Matthew 11:16-19

- In what ways are people today like the children described in this passage?

Matthew 11:20-24

- Why did Jesus denounce the cities? What does this tell me regarding Jesus’ highest desire for me (cf. 4:17)?

Matthew 11:28-30

“His easy yoke is neither cheap nor convenient. The surprising promise of the easy yoke was meant to free us from a self-serving, meritorious, performance-based religion. It is easy in that it frees us from the burden of self-centeredness; liberates us from the load of self-righteousness; and frees us to live in the way that God intended us to live. The easy yoke sounds like an oxymoron. Plowing a field or pulling a load is hard work! And nowhere does Jesus promise soft ground for tilling or level paths for bearing the load. What he does promise is a relationship with Himself. The demands are great but the relationship with Jesus makes the burden light.”¹⁵

- What are the things that cause people to “labor” and be “heavy laden,” and how does Jesus give rest to those who come to him?

13. Frank E. Gaebelein, *Gen. Ed. Expositor's Bible Commentary CD* (Zondervan, 1992).

14. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004), 411–17.

15. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004), 428

Wednesday, September 16, 2026

Bible Text: Matthew 12 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 12:1-12

- How does this passage expose the Pharisees' failure to see the real needs of the disciples? What is revealed about their understanding of piety and of God in their willingness to rescue a sheep on the Sabbath but not see a man get healed?

Matthew 12:22-32

- How does this passage show the reality of two opposing kingdoms in this world, and what parallels are there between the Pharisees' way of thinking and the mindset of modern-day critics of Christianity?

Matthew 12:33-37

- For what will men have to give account on the day of judgment? How does this passage challenge me regarding my speech?

Matthew 12:43-45

- What warning does this passage give to those who “clean up their act” but do not allow God to take control over their lives?

Matthew 12:46-50

- How does Jesus' new conception of family challenge the way the world defines and values family? What impact would this have had on early Christianity?

Thursday, September 17, 2026

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Scripture Memory: Psalm 16

Please feel free to use the space below to review and memorize the passage.

Bible Text: Matthew 13 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 13:1-23

- Notice the progression of the types of soil, beginning from the hardened path; to shallow, rocky soil; to thorny soil; and finally the good soil. What can I do today to move toward good soil?

Matthew 13:24-28

“‘Sleeping’ (v. 25) does not imply that the servants were neglectful but that the enemy was stealthy and malicious. What he sowed was *zizania* (‘weeds’—almost certainly bearded darnel (*lolium temulentum*), which is botanically close to wheat and difficult to distinguish from it when the plants are young).”¹⁶

- How does the picture of ‘weeds among the wheat’ describe the relationship between Christians and the world, and the reality of spiritual battle?

Matthew 13:31-33

“If there is a distinction between this parable and the last one, it is that the mustard seed suggests extensive growth and the yeast intensive transformation.”¹⁷

- What aspects of the gospel make the comparisons to a mustard seed and to leaven especially fitting?

Matthew 13:44-50

- How does the context of final judgment highlight the wisdom of the drastic actions taken by the man who found the treasure and the merchant looking for fine pearls?

Matthew 13:53-58

- On what basis did the townspeople deny Jesus’ spiritual authority and message, and what does this reveal about human nature?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

16. Frank E. Gaebelin, *Gen. Ed. Expositor’s Bible Commentary CD* (Zondervan, 1992).
17. *Ibid.*

Bible Text: Matthew 14 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 14:1-11

- Consider the progression in this passage, starting with Herod’s reaction to John’s message. What can I learn about the human tendency to resist uncomfortable truth, and how might that help me examine my own life?

Matthew 14:13-21

- What was Jesus’ original plan, and how does his example challenge me regarding how I respond to interruptions to my plans?
- How does the disciples’ role in this miraculous feeding of the multitudes show the weight of my own obedience to Jesus’ commands, “You give them something to eat” and “Bring them here to me”?

Matthew 14:22-23

- After an exhausting day, Jesus still sought solitude with God. What priority does prayer hold in my life?
- Jesus withdrew to pray after hearing about John’s execution (vv. 12-13). How do I usually process personal grief or emotional distress?

Matthew 14:25-33

- How does Peter’s response highlight what it means to step toward Jesus in faith? What might I need to let go of in order to do the same in my life?
- How does Jesus catching Peter even as he sinks give me confidence to venture out and take risks for God?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Tuesday, September 22, 2026

Bible Text: Matthew 15 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 15:1-2, 10-20

- Contrast the Pharisees' view of cleanliness with Jesus' view. What might explain how or why the Pharisees became so focused on external rituals like hand-washing as a way to spiritual purity?

Matthew 15:21-28

- Consider what drove the Canaanite woman to Jesus, and how this might reframe my perspective toward difficult situations in my life.
- What about the Canaanite woman's response led Jesus to praise her as having great faith, and what is the picture of faith her example provides?

Matthew 15:29-39

- Given the contrast between the crowd's need and the disciples' meager provisions, what does Jesus' question in v. 34 reveal about how he sees the situation differently from the disciples?
- Reflect on how Jesus used the seven loaves and "a few small fish." How am I challenged and encouraged to release the few "loaves" and "fish" I have?

Bible Text: Matthew 16 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 16:1-4

- Consider Jesus’ frustration expressed in vv. 2-4. How is it that people might be good at “how to interpret the appearance of the sky” yet be spiritually dull?

Matthew 16:13-20

“Christianity never consists in knowing about Jesus; it always consists in knowing Jesus. Jesus Christ demands a personal verdict. He did not ask only Peter, he asks every man: ‘You – what do you think of me?’”¹⁸

- What does v. 15 reveal about the essence of the gospel, and how does my confession align with Peter’s declaration that Jesus is “the Christ, the son of the living God”?
- What authority does Jesus give to the church, and how does this responsibility impact the way I live?

Matthew 16:21-23

- Consider the ways those closest to me can become a “hindrance” because they “are not setting their mind on the things of God, but on the things of man,” or situations where my protective love can actually hinder them from obeying God. What does this reveal about the nature of human love and loyalty?

Matthew 16:24-27

“Losing one’s life to Jesus means giving over one’s own will to follow him alone in discovering God’s will as the central, driving force for one’s life. This concept echoes later in Paul’s declaration, ‘Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation; the old has gone, the new has come!’ (2 Cor. 5:17). The new life of the kingdom of God is discovered only by giving over to Jesus one’s old life and finding new life in following him.”¹⁹

- What are the two kinds of “life” presented in this passage, and what is the relationship between the two?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

18. William Barclay, *The Gospel of Matthew: Volume 2* (The Westminster Press, 1975), 138.
19. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004), 552–88.

Thursday, September 24, 2026

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Friday, September 25, 2026

Scripture Memory: Psalm 16

Please feel free to use the space below to review and memorize the passage.

Bible Text: Matthew 17 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 17:1-3

“The ‘six days’ probably indicates the time it took to travel from Caesarea Philippi (16:13) to the high mountains (17:1); that is, the Transfiguration took place within a few days of the prediction that Jesus must go to Jerusalem and be killed. The two passages must therefore be read together. [...] Those Jesus ‘took with him’ were Peter, James, and John, the inner circle of the Twelve.”²⁰

- What can I learn from the fact that the transfiguration event took place after Jesus plainly told the disciples about his death (cf. Matt 16:21-28)? What does this show about the true meaning of “glory” in Christian life?

Matthew 17:14-20

- Why is Jesus so frustrated with the disciples' lack of faith?
- Reflect on Jesus' words: "Bring him here to me." Who are the people I need to bring to Jesus?

Matthew 17:24-27

- Although Jesus makes it clear that “the sons are free,” he goes on to pay the taxes. What wisdom about Christian life is Jesus teaching here?

20. Frank E. Gaebelin, *Gen. Ed. Expositor's Bible Commentary CD* (Zondervan, 1992).

Monday, September 28, 2026

Bible Text: Matthew 18 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 18:1-6, 10-14

- What misunderstanding about the kingdom of heaven does the disciples' question reveal, and in what ways am I like the disciples, seeking to be great?

Matthew 18:7-10

"Jesus now addresses the disciples directly about their personal responsibility for their own actions. Lest they deceive themselves into thinking that all sinful behavior is the result of others causing them to sin, Jesus declares that they must take responsibility for their own tendencies to cause themselves to sin (again *skandalizo*, as in 18:6). Similar to the hyperbole in the Sermon on the Mount (5:29-30), Jesus indicates that cutting off one's hand or foot or plucking out one's eye in this life (18:8-9) is no comparison to the eternal judgment destined for allowing the passions of one's own life to lead one into sin. Jesus is not advocating physical self-mutilation, but through dramatic figures of speech he indicates the rigorous self-discipline needed for committed disciples."²¹

"'Little ones' does not only mean children, but those who humble themselves like children as Jesus described. It is a wicked thing to sin, and it is a far greater evil to lead others into sin."²²

- What kind of drastic measures am I called to take to deal with sins in my life? What should be my motivation?

Matthew 18:15-20

"At its widest what Jesus was saying was, 'If anyone sins against you, spare no effort to make that man admit his fault, and to get things right again between you and him.' Basically it means that we must never tolerate any situation in which there is a breach of personal relationships between us and another member of the Christian community."²³

- What can I learn from the process that Jesus advises in leading a brother to repent?

Matthew 18:21-22

- What perspective regarding forgiveness does Peter's question reveal, and what does Jesus' answer reveal about God's heart?

Matthew 18:23-35

"The total revenue of the province which contained Idumaea, Judaea and Samaria was only 600 talents; the total revenue of even a wealthy province like Galilee was only 300 talents. Here was a debt which was greater than a king's ransom."²⁴

- What do the servant's words reveal about his self-understanding? How would he have felt upon receiving the king's mercy?
- How does the servant's treatment toward his fellow servant expose ways I might forget God's mercy and overly focus on the sins of others?

21. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004), 609–40.

22. David Guzik, "Matthew Chapter 18," *Enduring Word Media*, 2004.

23. William Barclay, *The Gospel of Matthew: Volume 2* (The Westminster Press, 1975), 187.

24. William Barclay, *The Gospel of Matthew: Volume 2* (The Westminster Press, 1975)

Tuesday, September 29, 2026

-52- AUGUST - NOVEMBER 2026 • ACTS2 NETWORK DEVOTIONALS

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Bible Text: Matthew 19 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 19:4-6

- What source of authority does Jesus turn to in answering their question about divorce, and in what ways can reading about what God wanted “from the beginning” clarify many issues in my life?
- Reflect on the words “male and female,” “a man,” “his wife,” “the two,” “one flesh,” “no longer two,” and “let not man separate.” What basic truths about God’s original design for marriage emerge from these words?

Matthew 19:16-26

- What does the man’s question “what good deed must I do to have eternal life” reveal about his view of the kingdom of heaven?

“[W]ealth is a heady intoxicant, because it provides most of the counterfeits that fool a person into thinking he or she does not need God.”²⁵

“[O]ne should be careful of the ‘deceitfulness of wealth.’ This passage does not suggest that wealth is wrong, however, but it does suggest that there is something about wealth that can choke off the effectiveness of the gospel and keep one from entering the kingdom.”²⁶

- Why must Jesus address the issue of wealth? What warning about wealth do I need to heed?

Matthew 19:27-29

- Jesus says that whoever leaves his brothers or sisters or father or mother or children or lands for his sake will receive a hundred times as much and will inherit eternal life. What does this reveal about what God truly wants for us?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

25. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004), 650.
26. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004), 658.

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Bible Text: Matthew 20 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 20:1-16

"In the context of Matthew's gospel there is another function of the parable. That is to answer Peter's question in Matthew 19:27. Peter had first made a claim and then asked his question. The claim was, 'We have left everything and followed you.' The question was essentially, 'What reward are we going to get for our special loyalty and love?' Peter's assumption is that he and the other disciples deserved a greater reward because of the greatness of their commitment to Christ. Jesus' reply makes it clear that God does not judge based on what is deserved, but on the basis of grace."²⁷

[... The] principle in the world is that he who works the longest receives the most pay. That is just. But in the kingdom of God the principles of merit and ability may be set aside so that grace can prevail."²⁸

- Reflect on the description of the hired men as "standing idle in the marketplace." In what ways does this characterize life apart from the meaningful labors of the kingdom of heaven?
- What is my reaction to the fact that there is no extra "reward" for serving God longer? What is my attitude towards God's generosity and grace towards others?

Matthew 20:17-28

"It is often ignorance that seeks leadership, power, and glory: the brothers do not know what they are asking. To ask to reign with Jesus is to ask suffer with him ... To ask for worldly wealth and much honor is often to ask for anxiety, temptation, disappointment, and envy; and in the spiritual arena to ask for great usefulness and reward is often to ask for great suffering (cf. 2 Cor 11:23-33; Col 1:24; Rev 1:9). [As Matthew Henry writes,] 'We know not what we ask, when we ask for the glory of wearing the crown, and ask not for grace to bear the cross on our way to it.'"²⁸

- Reflect on the inappropriateness of James and John's request (made through their mother) immediately after Jesus' detailed predictions of his suffering and crucifixion. What does this show about what happens to my heart when I seek personal gain and ascendancy?

Matthew 20:25-28

- Reflect on Jesus' teaching about greatness and servanthood.

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

²⁷ Roger Han, "Biblical and Theological Resources for Growing Christians", Christian Resource Institute, <http://www.cresourcei.org/biblestudy/bbmatt15.html>.

²⁸ Frank E. Gaebelin, *Gen. Ed. Expositor's Bible Commentary CD* (Zondervan, 1992).

²⁹ Ibid.

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Scripture Memory: Psalm 23

Please feel free to use the space below to review and memorize the passage.

Bible Text: Matthew 21 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 21:1-11

“The crowds shout out ‘Hosanna,’ which is the transliteration of the Hebrew expression that means ‘O save’ (cf. 2 Sam. 14:4; 2 Kings 6:26)... They further cry out to Jesus as ‘Son of David’ (21:9). Linked with Hosanna, the title ‘Son of David’ is unmistakably messianic. The crowd acknowledges what Jesus has already stated in his fulfillment of Zechariah 9:9: He is the Davidic Messiah...on whom they call to save them out of their oppression.”³⁰

- Reflect on the ways in which “Hosanna” captures the deepest cry of the human heart.

Matthew 21:12-17

- What is so offensive and tragic about what was happening in the temple? Are there ways I have failed to take into consideration God’s standards by allowing worldly values and practices to be the norm in my life?

Matthew 21:23-27

“‘John’s baptism’ (v. 25) is a way of referring to the Baptist’s entire ministry... Jesus asks whether that ministry was from heaven or from men.”³¹

“They cannot alienate the people by saying that John’s highly popular prophetic ministry was not from God. They fear that the people may turn against them and cause an uprising (21:26), which would jeopardize the Roman support of their leadership. But neither can they endorse the very prophet who had condemned them for not repenting (cf. Matthew 3:7-10)... These religious leaders recognize the dilemma Jesus has put them in, so they refuse to answer. That refusal shows their dishonesty, and they must accept their culpability.”³²

- Jesus’ question forces them to take a stance that would have far-reaching consequences in their lives. What practical calculations do the priests and elders consider, and what does this reveal about their attitude toward truth?

Matthew 21:28-32

“The shock value of Jesus’ statement can only be appreciated when the low esteem in which tax collectors (see on 5:46) were held, not to mention prostitutes, is taken into account ... But Jesus is saying that the scum of society, though it says no to God, repents, performs the Father’s will, and enters the kingdom, whereas the religious authorities loudly say yes to God but never do what he says, and therefore they fail to enter.”³³

- What does this parable teach about real obedience, and what warning is there about the consequences of making empty promises but not following through?

Matthew 21:33-42

“Many absentee landowners were notorious for their harsh treatment of their tenants. Here, the scene is reversed, and the landowner’s servants are abused when they come to collect a portion of the harvest. The landowner continues to send servants to collect what is rightfully his, but each is treated the same way (22:36). The treatment of these ‘servants’ calls to mind the

30. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004), 687.

31. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary DVD: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004).

32. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004), 695–96.

33. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary DVD: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004).

Monday, October 5, 2026

same fate that befell God's prophets throughout Old Testament history (e.g., 1 Kings 18:4; Jer. 20:1–2). Jesus will soon hold the teachers of the law and Pharisees culpable for the ill fate of the prophets and wise men sent to Israel (cf. Matt. 23:34).³⁴

- What is absurd about the tenants' response to the landowner's request? What basic truths did the tenants disregard in pursuing their course?

34. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary DVD: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004).

Monday, October 5, 2026

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Bible Text: Matthew 22 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 22:1-14

“It was customary for the wedding guest to be given garments to wear to the banquet. It was unthinkable to refuse to wear these garments. That would insult the host, who could only assume that the guest was arrogant and thought that he did not need these garments or that he did not want to take part in the wedding celebration. [...] Christ has provided this garment of righteousness to everyone, but each person must choose to put it on in order to enter the King’s banquet (eternal life).”³⁵

- In what way does vv. 8-10 capture the gospel?

Matthew 22:19-21

“Coinage in the ancient world had significant political power. Rulers issued coins with their own image and inscription on them. In a certain sense, the coin was regarded as his personal property. Where the coin was valid, the ruler held political sway over the people.”³⁶

- What does Jesus’ answer imply about God’s ownership over our lives? How should this affect the way I view my money, time, resources, etc.?

Matthew 22:23-30

- How does Jesus characterize the Sadducees’ reasoning in v. 29? What might be the reasons that the Sadducees could read Scripture and yet know “neither the Scriptures nor the power of God”?

Matthew 22:34-40

- Reflect on Jesus’ simple and clear summary of God’s commands. How have I obeyed these commands in my life?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

35. *NIV Life Application Bible* (Zondervan, 1991), 1698.
36. Don Schwager, Comment on Bible Sharing Online, 5 June 2012, <https://biblesharingonline.wordpress.com/2012/06/05/repay-to-caesar-what-belongs-to-caesar-our-gospel-for-june-5-2012/>.

Tuesday, October 6, 2026

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Bible Text: Matthew 23 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 23:1-7

- How did the scribes and the Pharisees lack integrity in their lives? What precautions do I need to take in order to avoid this?

Matthew 23:13-15

- What are some of the ways I might inadvertently shut the kingdom of heaven in men's faces by my example?

Matthew 23:23-24

“Jesus does not condemn scrupulous observance in these things (‘without neglecting the former’), but insists that to fuss over them while neglecting the ‘more important matters of the law’ (cf. 22:34-40)—justice, mercy, and *pistis* (here rightly translated ‘faithfulness’)—is to strain out a gnat but swallow a camel (23:24), both unclean creatures.”³⁷

- What “weightier matters” does Jesus refer to here, and what lesser concerns about Christian living distract me from understanding more deeply the fundamental truths of the gospel?

Matthew 23:29-32

“We sometimes think, if we had lived when Christ was upon earth, that we should not have despised and rejected him, as men then did; yet Christ in his Spirit, in his word, in his ministers, is still no better treated.”³⁸

- What might have caused the Pharisees to think that they were above the deeds of their forefathers?

Matthew 23:37-39

- Reflect on the heart of Jesus as he lamented over Jerusalem.

37. Frank E. Gaebelin, *Gen. Ed. Expositor's Bible Commentary CD* (Zondervan, 1992).

38. Matthew Henry, "Commentary on Matthew 23," *Matthew Henry Concise Commentary on the Whole Bible* (Crosswalk, 1706).

Wednesday, October 7, 2026

Handwriting practice area consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Wednesday, October 7, 2026

Bible Text: Matthew 24 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 24:1-14

- According to this passage, what will make it difficult for people to stand firm to the end?
- How can I prevent my love from growing cold so that I can continue to share in God’s heart?

Matthew 24:3-8

“Though none of those events are the specific sign of the end of the age, collectively they are a sign. When Jesus described these calamities as the beginning of sorrows He literally called them the beginning of labor pains. Just as is true with labor pains, we should expect that the things mentioned – wars, famines, earthquakes, and so on – would become more frequent and more intense before the return of Jesus.”³⁹

- How am I living in response to the certainty of the second coming of Jesus and the “end of the age”?

Matthew 24:15-35

- What kind of character, or attitude, will be required of those at the end times if they are to follow the words of vv. 17-18?

Matthew 24:36-41

- Think about the description of what people were doing “until the day Noah entered the ark.” What precautions do I need to take in order to not be in the same predicament as these people?

Matthew 24:42-51

- What does the master consider wicked, and what would wickedness look like in my context, as a servant entrusted by God with work to be faithful in?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

39. David Guzik, “Matthew Chapter 24,” The Enduring Word Bible Commentary, <https://enduringword.com/bible-commentary/matthew-24/>.

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 25 horizontal dotted lines.

Scripture Memory: Psalm 23

Please feel free to use the space below to review and memorize the passage.

Bible Text: Matthew 25 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 25:1-13

"But the parable has at least two universal warnings. [...] It warns us that there are certain things which cannot be obtained at the last minute. [...] Similarly, it is easy to leave things so late that we can no longer prepare ourselves to meet with God. [...] It warns us that there are certain things which cannot be borrowed. The foolish virgins found it impossible to borrow oil, when they discovered they needed it. A man cannot borrow a relationship with God; he must possess it for himself. A man cannot borrow a character; he must be clothed with it. We cannot always be living on the spiritual capital which others have amassed. There are certain things we must win or acquire for ourselves, for we cannot borrow them from others."⁴⁰

- What realities did the foolish ones ignore, and how does this parable challenge a casual approach to Christian life?

Matthew 25:14-30

- How does the master's identical praise for both the two and five talent servants show what God values, as well as highlight the folly of the one talent servant's response to receiving one talent?
- How does faithfulness lead to partaking in God's joy?

Matthew 25:31-46

This is one of the most vivid parables Jesus ever spoke, and the lesson is crystal clear – that God will judge us in accordance with our reaction to human need. His judgment does not depend on the knowledge we have amassed, or the fame that we have acquired, or the fortune that we have gained, but on the help that we have given.”⁴¹

- Reflect on the fact that those “who are cursed into the eternal fire” are largely guilty for what they did not do.

Matthew 25:1-46

- Reflect on the three parables in this chapter. How can I concretely heed the warnings from each of these parables?

40. William Barclay, *The Gospel of Matthew: Volume 2*, (The Westminster Press, 1975), 320–21.

41. William Barclay, *The Gospel of Matthew: Volume 2*, (The Westminster Press, 1975), 325–26.

Monday, October 12, 2026

Monday, October 12, 2026

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 25 horizontal dotted lines.

Bible Text: Matthew 26 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 26:6-13

- How does the woman with the alabaster jar challenge my view of what is beautiful? How can I live a more beautiful life?

Matthew 26:14-16

“Judas, therefore, sold Jesus for less than five pounds. If avarice was the cause of his act of treachery, it is the most terrible example in history of the depths which love of money can reach...”

“It may be that Judas was [a zealot], and that he had looked on Jesus as the divinely sent leader, who...could lead the great rebellion. He may have seen that Jesus had deliberately taken another way, the way that led to a cross... Judas may have hated Jesus because he was not the Christ he wished him to be.”

“He may have thought that Jesus was proceeding far too slowly; and he may have wished for nothing else than to force his hand. He may have betrayed Jesus with the intention of compelling him to act.”

“[T]he tragedy of Judas is that he refused to accept Jesus as he was and tried to make him what he wanted him to be. It is not Jesus who can be changed by us, but we who must be changed by Jesus. We can never use him for our purposes; we must submit to be used for his. The tragedy of Judas is that of a man who thought he knew better than God.”⁴²

- How does Judas’ response to Jesus illustrate the nature of sin? In what areas of my life do I have the attitude of Judas?

Matthew 26:30-46

- Are there ways I can relate to Peter, overestimating myself and dismissing warnings?

Matthew 26:36-39

“Jesus does not ask them to pray but to watch. As he grievously anticipates his looming death, his overwhelming sorrow reveals a heart broken almost to the point of death itself, because he knows that he will experience his Father’s forsakenness (cf. 27:46). This reveals the depth of Jesus’ human relationships he feels is necessary to sustain him in his time of greatest need. It may be difficult to grasp that the Son of God had such needs, but to do so gives us a more adequate understanding of his incarnation.”⁴³

- Reflect on the fact that Jesus was “very sorrowful even to death.” What does this say regarding Jesus’ humility and vulnerability? Are there situations in my life where I need to pray, “Nevertheless, not as I will, but as you will”?

Matthew 26:65-68

“To this day when a man is brought face to face with Jesus Christ, he must either hate him or love him; he must either submit to him, or desire to destroy him. No man who realizes what Jesus Christ demands can possibly be neutral. He must either be his liege-man or his foe.”⁴⁴

- Why did the people respond so violently to Jesus’ claim? What could have led to these people being so wrong about Jesus, and what warning is there for me?

42. William Barclay, *The Gospel of Matthew: Volume 2*, (The Westminster Press, 1975), 327–32.

43. Michael J. Wilkins, *Zondervan Illustrated Bible Backgrounds Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2002), 162–63.

44. William Barclay, *The Gospel of Matthew: Volume 2*, (The Westminster Press, 1975), 356.

Tuesday, October 13, 2026

Matthew 26:74-75

- Observe the honesty of the gospels to show this kind of humiliating picture of Peter, the rock of the Christian church. What truth about the gospel does this reveal?

MATTHEW • GALATIANS • EZRA -77-

Tuesday, October 13, 2026

Bible Text: Matthew 27 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 27:1-10

- What does the response of the chief priests reveal about the helplessness of sinners to find forgiveness from human courts?
- What is tragic about the response of both Judas and the priests?

Matthew 27:41-44

“At the beginning of Jesus’ ministry, the devil tempted Jesus in the same way (4:3, 6); now the people throw another cruel temptation at him to escape the cross: ‘Come down from the cross, if you are the Son of God!’ Their taunt says more than they know, but Jesus will continue to pursue the Father’s will, as he resolutely affirmed three times in Gethsemane (26:39 – 44). Matthew’s readers will hear in these taunts from the passersby another allusion to Psalm 22: ‘But I am a worm and not a man, scorned by men and despised by the people. All who see me mock me; they hurl insults, shaking their heads’ (Ps. 22:6 – 7).”⁴⁵

- How is the attitude of “save yourself” manifested in the world today, and in what situations are the voices that tell me to “save [my]self” the loudest?

Matthew 27:45-46

“Not only does Jesus bear the load of humanity’s sin, but he becomes sin on our behalf (see 2 Cor. 5:21). He became cursed by God for us, ‘for it is written: “Cursed is everyone who is hung on a tree”’ (Gal. 3:13). William Hendriksen comments graphically on the darkness that portends Jesus’ cry: The darkness meant judgment, the judgment of God upon our sins, his wrath as it were burning itself out in the very heart of Jesus, so that he, as our Substitute, suffered most intense agony, indescribable woe, terrible isolation or forsakenness. Hell came to Calvary that day, and the Savior descended into it and bore its horrors in our stead.”⁴⁶

- Reflect on Jesus’ suffering and darkness as he bore the weight of my sin.

Matthew 27:51-54

“This large blue, purple and scarlet curtain separated the Holy Place from the Most Holy Place, an inner room which symbolized God’s presence (Exodus 26:31-33). It was, in effect, the barrier that separated people from God. When God supernaturally tore the curtain (perhaps by earthquake) he showed dramatically that Christ’s death had given people access to God (Heb. 9:1-15; 10:19-22).”⁴⁷

- How do the torn temple curtain and the opened tombs illustrate what Christ has accomplished through his death?

45. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004), 900.

46. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004).

47. “Matthew 27:51,” *Quest Study Bible* (Zondervan, 1994), 1432.

Wednesday, October 14, 2026

-80- AUGUST - NOVEMBER 2026 • ACTS2 NETWORK DEVOTIONALS

Bible Text: Matthew 28 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Matthew 28:1-8

“Most of the same women who courageously witnessed Jesus’ gruesome crucifixion and burial plan to visit the tomb in order to assist the family in finalizing the body for burial. Jewish custom permitted both men and women to prepare corpses, with women allowed to attend to corpses of either gender but men not allowed to attend to women’s corpses. The women go to the place where Jesus was laid prior to the Sabbath.”⁴⁸

- What is the significance of the angel reminding the women that Jesus had risen “as he said”? Are there any areas in my life where I need to cling to God’s words over my emotions and expectations?

Matthew 28:5-10, 16-20

- What can I learn about the simplicity of being a witness in the angel’s commands to “come see,” and then “go quickly and tell”?
- How do the words “All authority,” “all nations,” and “I am with you always” challenge any limitations that I place on myself in obeying the Great Commission?
- In what ways can I concretely obey Jesus’ final charge to all his followers?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

48. Michael J. Wilkins, *The NIV Application Commentary: Matthew* (Zondervan, 2004).

Thursday, October 15, 2026

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Scripture Memory: Psalm 23

Please feel free to use the space below to review and memorize the passage.

Bible Text: Galatians 1 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Galatians 1:1-11

“v. 11 In distinguishing the gospel from “something that man made up” Apostle Paul is suggesting that the message of the Judaizers (i.e., those who were preaching “a different gospel—which is really no gospel at all,” v. 6-7) were “man made” and not the intent of God’s heart. Judaizers were Jewish Christians who believed, among other things, that a number of the ceremonial practices of the OT were still binding on the NT church, especially circumcision. As Apostle Paul would explain in later chapters, the Judaizers misunderstood even the O.T., and missed God’s heart in turning a relationship with him into adherence to ceremonial rules.”⁴⁹

- Why would men “make up” such an approach to God, in that it would seem to involve adding, rather than taking away, certain burdens to their religious life?
- What are some examples of similar man-made approaches to God among Christians today?

Galatians 1:15-21

- For Paul, it was very evident that he was not riding on the coat-tails of the other apostles’ faith and convictions. To what extent are my convictions regarding the truth of the gospel of Jesus Christ my own, and how can I strengthen my personal convictions?

Galatians 1:22

- It is remarkable that Paul, a man zealous and accomplished in Judaism and a persecutor of the Gospel, had turned into a preacher of the faith he once tried to destroy. The result was that people “glorified God because of me.” In what way does my personal testimony of conversion reveal a similar reversal?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

49. “Introduction to Galatians,” *The NIV Study Bible* (Zondervan, 2002), 1819.

Monday, October 19, 2026

Bible Text: Galatians 2 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Galatians 2:3-4

- The Judaizers among their midst had been preaching that Gentile Christians must follow the Laws of Moses such as circumcision to be saved. What would have been the consequences if Apostle Paul had given in to the demands of the Judaizers?
- Who are the people in my life for whose sake I should not give into compromising voices?

Galatians 2:11-15

- What can I learn from Apostle Paul openly opposing Peter? Why was this necessary?
- Peter “drew back” and “separated” himself from the Gentiles because he was afraid of those who belonged to the circumcision group. What are some situations where people change their views or practices regarding their faith because of external pressures?

Galatians 2:20

- How have I experienced this verse in my life? What are some aspects of my life before Christ that have been crucified with him, and in what ways is it now true that “I no longer live, but Christ lives in me”?

Tuesday, October 20, 2026

Bible Text: Galatians 3 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Galatians 3:3-5

- How has the promise that I have been made righteous in God's eyes through the work of Christ on behalf of sinners transformed the way I view myself, relate with others, and look to the future?

Galatians 3:13-14

- To die “hanging from a tree” was an indication that the man was cursed by God. What profound truth about the cross does this reveal?

Galatians 3:15-18

- Apostle Paul makes the point that the Mosaic Law was given after God gave the covenantal promise to Abraham. How does that clear away the misconception that obedience to God's law is a prerequisite to becoming his people? If obedience to the laws is not a prerequisite, then what is the purpose of obeying the commands and laws of God?

Galatians 3:26-27

- What might it look like to “put on” Christ? How am I challenged to accurately represent Christ through my speech and conduct in my various contexts?

Wednesday, October 21, 2026

Handwriting practice area consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Bible Text: Galatians 4 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Galatians 4:1-7

- Reflect on the meaning of the word “heir” and the fact that through Jesus we have become sons, and therefore, heirs of God. What would it look like for me to deeply embrace this truth and live out its implications?

Galatians 4:15-16

“The Galatians were being besieged by false teachers who were seeking to teach a false gospel that taught that the strict observance of Jewish law and tradition was required for salvation. Paul saw this as an attempt to corrupt the gospel in order to minimize the persecution they would receive (cf. Gal 6:12). By adhering to the observance of all the requirements of Judaism, they would not receive criticism and persecution from the Jews. Because Paul opposed this false teaching and insisted on teaching the truth, he anticipated being considered an enemy by the Galatians.”

- What is my posture toward those who speak truth into my life?
- Are there any relationships in which fear of rejection has made me hesitant to be faithful in speaking the truth?

Galatians 4:19

- How am I challenged by Apostle Paul's willingness to bear the "anguish of childbirth" to see Christ formed in the people he is ministering to? What are some pains I might have to endure in order to mature as a minister of the gospel?

Thursday, October 22, 2026

Scripture Memory: Psalm 23

Please feel free to use the space below to review and memorize the passage.

Bible Text: Galatians 5 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Galatians 5:1-6

- Reflect on the words: “For freedom Christ has set us free.” To what extent have I recognized this as true in my life? List the ways in which Christ has set me free.

Galatians 5:13-15

- How is the use of freedom for Christians radically different from the way of the world?
- Reflect on how I've been using my God-given freedom. In what ways can I increase in loving my neighbor as myself?

Galatians 5:16-18

- What do these verses teach me about the nature of Christian life and how I can combat my sinful desires?

Galatians 5:19-25

- Identify the acts of the sinful nature that reside within my heart or manifest in my life. What would it look like to crucify the sinful nature with its passions and desires? How can I nurture the growth of the fruits of the Spirit?
- Reflect on the fruit of the Spirit listed in this passage. Which areas in my life show signs of growth, and which still need cultivation?

Monday, October 26, 2026

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Monday, October 26, 2026

Bible Text: Galatians 6 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Galatians 6:1-6

- What key phrases stand out in this passage, and what do they teach about the reality of sin, the work of restoration, and the church's role?

Galatians 6:7-10

- How is it “mocking God” when a person sows to please his sinful nature yet thinks he can reap spiritual fruit?
- As I think about times of frustration in my spiritual growth, what insight does this passage provide about how growth happens?
- Why does Apostle Paul tell us to do good to all people, and then highlight a focused responsibility toward fellow believers in the household of faith?

Galatians 6:12-16

- How does it follow that those who want to avoid being persecuted for the cross of Christ will focus on making a “good showing in the flesh”?
- What would it look like for a person to boast in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ?

Tuesday, October 27, 2026

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Ezra 1 Commentary⁵⁰

1:1 Not surprisingly, the beginning of Ezra commences with the beginning of Cyrus, whose arrival in Babylon in 539 BCE and proclamation in 538 offered both powers and pretenders conclusive evidence of his meteoric rise from the provinces of Media. While the first verse of Ezra begins and ends with Cyrus, the syntactical heart of 1:1 is profoundly theological: “YHWH moved.”

1:2 While the tradition strongly associates Israel’s God with sovereignty over the heavens (e.g., Genesis, Deuteronomy, Psalms), it is suggested that the use of the specific title “the God of heaven” within the edict of Cyrus reflects Persian usage. [...] The use of this terminology among the returnees (cf. Ezra 5:12; 6:9–10; Neh 1:4–5; 2:4, 20 etc.) may then reflect an accommodation to imperial expectation, rather than a novel and original use of the title by the exiles. That YHWH has given Cyrus “all the kingdoms,” however, confirms that this heavenly God has earthly interests and intentions, while his charge to build YHWH a house in Jerusalem illustrates the conviction of the returnees, not only that their God has the power to move the “powers that be,” but also that his own worship is his chief priority.

1:3–4 [...] for Jews about to embark upon a journey to a land that was once promised, this invocation of their God’s presence “with them” might find a resonance rather in the exodus generation’s hope that their God would go with them on their own journey out of a foreign land (cf. Exod 34:9; Num 14:8–9). The edict’s suggestion that their God might be both “with them” and “in Jerusalem” poses no difficulty for those who conceived of their God in incorporeal terms in any case, though the association of the divine presence with Jerusalem will be expressed regularly in the early chapters of Ezra (e.g., 4:24; 5:2). That the Jews should return with more than “their God” is made explicit in 1:4, which encourages material support for the returnees and especially the temple, even if it is unclear whether such support should be expected from those Jews who were not willing or able to make the journey or from Gentile neighbors, on the pattern of the despoiling of the Egyptians found in the exodus tradition.

1:5–6 While in the prayer of Neh 9, it is the divine spirit’s tutelage of the exodus generation (Exod 9:20) that is remembered, here special note is made of the power of God’s spirit to stir up the people to embrace the opportunity to return to Jerusalem. That this spiritual encouragement was necessary may suggest that the journey was perceived to be a daunting one and may also imply that not all of the

“heads of Benjamin and Judah, priests and Levites” were willing to make the trip. However, the emphasis here is laid very much on the receptivity and spiritual sensitivity of those who did so and the divine initiative of YHWH, who stirs up or rouses, not only the “powers that be” like Cyrus (1:1) but also the people themselves.

1:7–11 That it is the Persian king himself who brings out the temple vessels (1:7) and then releases them into the charge of a royal treasurer, Mithredath (1:8), is further confirmation of the divine Spirit’s stirring of Cyrus, while the mention of Nebuchadnezzar’s plundering of the temple (2 Kgs 24:13; 25:13–16; 2 Chr 36:10) invites the reader to reflect on the ultimate sovereignty of the God of heaven over even the greatest sovereigns of the earth. The writer’s attention to the facts and figures (Ezra 1:9–10) of the temple vessels reflects the importance of the return of what was taken and the notion of careful (ac)counting reflected also in 1 Chr 9:28, which relates the practice of counting the vessels when they were brought into the temple for use and again when they were taken out. Having been taken out of the temple by Nebuchadnezzar in the most traumatic of circumstances, this precious paraphernalia is now “counted” out of the house of Cyrus’s gods to ensure that all that should return to the temple does so.⁵⁰

50. David J. Shepherd and Christopher J.H. Wright, *The Two Horizons Old Testament Commentary: Ezra and Nehemiah* (Eerdmans Publishing Co., 2018), 13–14.

Bible Text: Ezra 1 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Ezra 1:1

- What can I learn about how God works from the fact that “the Lord stirred up the spirit of Cyrus king of Persia, so that he made a proclamation”?

Ezra 1:2

- Given Cyrus's high position and power, why is it amazing that he says that God "has given me all the kingdoms of the earth, and he has charged me to build him a house at Jerusalem, which is in Judah"?
- How does Cyrus's view of his personal accomplishments and blessings contrast with mine?

Ezra 1:5-11

- What is notable about the people's response?

Wednesday, October 28, 2026

Ezra 2 Commentary⁵¹

2:1–2 The mention again of Nebuchadnezzar and the circumstances of exile signals a reemphasizing of the continuity of the returnees with the original exiles. That it was their own towns to which they returned reflects and depends on the divinely sanctioned division and allocation of the land described in Numbers and Joshua. Whether intentional or not, the listing of twelve leaders (not including Sheshbazzar) would likely have offered early readers an echo of the twelve sons of Jacob and the eponymous tribes that descended from them. Though not emphasized here, Zerubbabel’s Davidic ancestry may well have reminded ancient readers of the hope of royal restoration (and thus the fulfillment of God’s promise to David in 2 Sam 7) that would wax and wane in the years following the return.

2:21–35 Beginning in 2:21 the focus of the list seems to shift from parentage to place...The interest in connecting the returning people to particular places reflects the historic concerns with (re)securing the land that had been promised by God in ancient times. If the people are listed by place name because they are “the poor of the land” (2 Kgs 25:12) who do not hold title to any ancestral property, the list reaffirms the community’s inclusion of those on the margins who might otherwise have fallen by the wayside on their return.

2:36–39 As in Numbers, where the priests and Levites are listed (Num 3–4) following the others (Num 1–2), so too here in connection with this new “exodus,” the attention moves from laity to priests and functionaries—the comparatively sizeable numbers of the latter offer a further indication that worship is not incidental, but remains central to the plans of God and his people.

2:40–42 As Ezra would himself eventually discover (8:15), comparatively few Levites made this journey (2:40). While singers and gatekeepers would later (1 Chr 6) be incorporated into the Levite ranks and classified according to descent (Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun), here they are reported separately. Collectively, they are further testimony to the cultic ambitions and commitments of the returning community.

2:43–58 It is very likely that the temple servants (lit., “given/devoted”), and the sons of Solomon’s servants were responsible for assisting the Levites with some of the most basic tasks relating to worship and the temple. If, as some of the names suggest, this group included foreigners (including, potentially, prisoners of war), their inclusion as

full members of the community (as we see in 2:64) suggests that the community continued to be inclusive within the limits of the tradition as they understood it.

2:59–63 The limits of the community’s inclusivity appear to have had implications for those who belonged to specific communities in exile but were unable to establish their genealogical credentials and/or connection to a traditional location in the ancestral land. While the implications remain unclear for the laity, the priests are excluded from facilitating the worshiping community. Given the emphasis on ensuring continuity with the community of origin, such a position, while appearing severe, would certainly have been understandable.

2:64–67 The total sum of the preceding numbers is considerably lower (by some 11,000) than the total given in 2:64. While it is possible, as in 1:9–11, that something has been lost in the preceding list, the more likely suggestion is that women have been included in the latter total, but not in the preceding numbers. Both men and women are included in the figures for servants/slaves (2:65), who are included along with the animals (2:66)—a notion that is as anathema to modern sensibilities as it was apparently unremarkable to ancient ones.

2:70 Given that some of the priests and temple functionaries clearly (and of necessity) settled in Jerusalem (Neh 3:26, 31; 11:21), why does the text here make a point of suggesting that both they and the rest of the people settled in their towns? By reiterating the same point at the end of the chapter, which he had made at the beginning (Ezra 2:1), the editor/narrator perhaps wishes to emphasize that the return was not merely a symbolic but also quite literal (re)settlement of the land as evidenced by the repopulation of not just Jerusalem, but also the wide variety of cities and towns that are indicated at great length in the lists found in Josh 15:21–62; 18:21–28.

51. David J. Shepherd and Christopher J.H. Wright, *The Two Horizons Old Testament Commentary: Ezra and Nehemiah* (Eerdmans Publishing Co., 2018), 14–15

Bible Text: Ezra 2 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Ezra 2:1

- What can I learn from these Israelite exiles who left the advanced civilization of Persia to return to a Jerusalem in ruins?

Ezra 2:36-57

- Reflect on the fact that the priests, Levites, gatekeepers and temple servants kept their identities intact during their exile in Babylon, even after the destruction of the Temple.
- What must I do in order to keep my identity intact throughout changing circumstances?
- What does the detailed listing of the names of those who returned reveal about God's heart?

Thursday, October 29, 2026

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 25 horizontal dotted lines.

Friday, October 30, 2026

Scripture Memory: Psalm 23

Please feel free to use the space below to review and memorize the passage.

Ezra 3 Commentary⁵²

3:2 The writer is keen to demonstrate not only that the restoration of the altar was done under the aegis of the appropriate religious (Jeshua et al.) and civic (Zerubbabel et al.) authorities, but also that it was done “according to what was written in the law of Moses, the man of God” (Exod 20:25). As others note, the latter phrase is applied to David (2 Chr 8:14; Neh 12:24, 36) and Moses (1 Chr 23:14; 2 Chr 30:16), particularly in contexts where Torah observance is emphasized, thus allowing the writer here to not only establish the contemporary continuity with the cultic past, but also the care with which the commandments were kept in the process of restoration.

3:3 The emphasizing of the restoration of the altar on the “(original) site” (or “foundations” if the plural of the Hebrew is read) and the reinstating of the appropriate daily sacrifices (as stipulated in Exod 29:38–42) appear to be a further reflection of the writer’s persistent concern to emphasize continuity with the past. Most striking of all, however, is the writer’s insistence that the returnees’ first recorded response to their “fear of the peoples” was to prepare for and recommence worship of their God.

3:4–6 Just as Solomon celebrates the Feast of Tabernacles (3:4) hard on the heels of the dedication of the first temple (1 Kgs 8:2) so too here the “harvest” festival originally associated with the exodus generation (Lev 23:33–36, 39–43) is celebrated by the returnees as worship recommences. That this takes place “as is written” and “by the numbers” specified in Torah, day by day, reaffirms the faithfulness of the returnees and specifically their care and attention to the worship life of the community.

3:7 [...] The writer’s description of, in this case, the gathering of supplies for the building of the temple appears to be influenced by the description in Chronicles of the building of the Solomonic temple (1 Chr 22:2–4; 2 Chr 2:7–15). Some returnees (and later readers) will have been aware of the prophetic word of Isa 60:13 to those exiled or returned: “The glory of Lebanon will come to you, the pine, the fir, and the cypress together, to adorn the place of my sanctuary; and I will glorify the place of my feet.” For them, the arrival of building materials will have been a reassurance that the God who had promised to restore was beginning to do so.

3:10–11 Rather than dwell on the mechanics of the reconstruction, the text is primarily interested in the character and intensity of the celebration that accompanies it. While we would expect such celebrations on momentous

occasions, the similarity of the language here to that associated with the first temple (2 Chr 7:6) seems to reflect an attempt to evoke those festivities. [...] While Ezra 2 emphasized the sacrificial involvement of the people themselves, this passage here—with its multiple mentions of praise and adoration of God (3:10, 11 [twice])—reflects and resonates with the remembered reality of God’s initiative and action in Ezra 1. Indeed, the psalmic refrain that is sung (3:11) leaves no space for self-importance among the returnees: it is not their piety or preservation of Torah and tradition that endures forever; rather it is God’s goodness and love that do so, and in their enduring, they make possible the repair, restoration, and renewal. That they endure “forever” is thus not only cause for gratitude, but also cause for hope.

3:12–13 Having duly noted the corporate liturgical celebration (3:10–11) of the progress that had been made, the writer now adds color to the scene by recounting the range of emotional responses among those gathered. Given the effort expended by the writer to illustrate the continuity of the new with the old, if the tears of those who had seen the former temple were ones of sadness (given the contrast drawn in 3:13 and perhaps Hag 2:3), they are at least confirmation that there were some who were able to assess and guarantee a sufficient degree of similarity. The writer’s curious insistence on emphasizing the impossibility of differentiating between joy and sadness suggests that the point is less the particular emotion expressed than the intensity and volume of their expression and their testimony to those beyond the community.

52. David J. Shepherd and Christopher J.H. Wright, *The Two Horizons Old Testament Commentary: Ezra and Nehemiah* (Eerdmans Publishing Co., 2018), 16–17.

Bible Text: Ezra 3 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Ezra 3:7-9

- Consider all the groups of people involved in building the temple, and their respective roles. What is my role in the body of Christ, and why is my faithfulness to it important?

Ezra 3:1 1

- Given the mention of the “Law of Moses” (v. 2) and the “directions of David” (v. 10), what connections would the people have felt as they were engaged in the rebuilding?
- What is there to celebrate about only the foundation being laid, when the completion of the building was still far away?
- What are some new beginnings for which I can be “praising and giving thanks to the Lord”?

Ezra 3:12-13

- In what sense are the joyful shouts and the people's weeping both appropriate?

Monday, November 2, 2026

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 25 horizontal dotted lines.

Ezra 4 Commentary⁵³

4:3 While the allusion to the Persian imperial edict is the explicit grounds for the returnees' rejection of cooperation, their emphasis on "our God" (cf. "your God" in 4:2) suggests that religious perceptions may lie at the root of their refusal. If this is the case, the problem may well have been the perception (or indeed reality) that even after two centuries, the practices of the immigrants' ancestors had continued (2 Kgs 17:41a notes that while these people were worshiping YHWH, they were also serving their idols). If so, given the Israelite tradition's insistence that it was the worship of gods alongside YHWH that was instrumental in the fall of both the northern and southern kingdoms, the returnees' reluctance is understandable, especially if involvement in rebuilding would have been understood to offer a precedent.

4:4–5 While we may assume that the people who set out to discourage (lit., "weaken the hands") and frighten off the returnees include those already mentioned, 4:5 suggests that others may have been added to their number over an extended period of time. The motif of external intimidation met here for the first time will be a recurring one in Ezra-Nehemiah. Having dwelt at length on the initial progress of the returnees, the writer here offers a justification for the temple remaining unfinished until the time of Darius.

4:12–13 While it is not clear precisely which group of returnees is being referred to or when they returned, that the foundations of the walls are still being repaired (4:12) indicates a time prior to the walls' completion in Nehemiah's time. Eventually the returnees themselves will confess their own wickedness and that of their predecessors (9:13). Here however the wickedness being alleged is clearly less theological than it is political, as may be seen from 4:13's rehearsal of the potential threats to the financial interests of the crown posed by the city's restoration.

4:17–20 Having offered greetings to his addressees (4:17) and confirmed receipt of their correspondence (4:18), the king reports his investigations and confirms their allegations (4:19). While some suppose that 4:20 might refer to Judean kings' own historic hegemony over and exploitation of what was now the Persian district, the tradition does not remember David—nor even Solomon in all his splendor—exercising authority over this entire region. Instead, the king reasons that if Jerusalem has paid taxes, tribute, and duty to his imperial predecessors in Babylon, then any activity that has the potential to reduce

or eliminate Jerusalem's contribution to his own coffers should be actively discouraged.

4:21–24 Royal investigation now gives way to instruction as the addressees are authorized to order the work to be stopped until the king decides otherwise (4:21). What might persuade the king to allow such work is unclear, but this final phrase may betray an awareness (or anticipation perhaps) of the sending of Nehemiah and the work that was eventually concluded under his supervision. Given that the obvious intention of the initial correspondence from Rehum and others was to halt the work, the king's warning in 4:22 has a slightly ironic ring about it. We are thus not surprised when the writer of Ezra informs us (4:23) that the king's instructions are acted upon "immediately" and with "full force" (lit., "with power and strength").

53. David J. Shepherd and Christopher J.H. Wright, *The Two Horizons Old Testament Commentary: Ezra and Nehemiah* (Eerdmans Publishing Co., 2018).

Bible Text: Ezra 4 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Ezra 4:4-6

- What emotional result did the adversaries of Judah and Benjamin hope to cause through their opposition to the rebuilding of the temple?
- Given the persistence and determination of the opposition, what attitude did the Israelites need in order to continue?
- What discouragement, fear, and frustration have I experienced in “building a temple to the Lord” (v. 1)?

Tuesday, November 3, 2026

Ezra 5 Commentary⁵⁴

5:1–2 Having described the frustration of the returnees’ later efforts to rebuild the city and the walls, the book of Ezra resumes the story of the temple, the reconstruction of which was, according to 4:5, halted until the time of Darius. [...] That the community of returnees continues to receive prophecies also reaffirms its identification with the people of the past and their prophets—not least those prophets who had promised that Judah and its people would be rebuilt. [...] Whether it is God or his name that is “over/upon them” and whether “them” refers to the prophets or the people or both, the text here seizes the opportunity to reemphasize that the resumption commences under the aegis of the God whose house they are rebuilding.

5:3–5 The news that those beyond the community approach the returnees “at the same time” as building recommences prepares the reader for opposition of the sort encountered later (but described already in Ezra 4). While there is nothing obviously malicious or malevolent about the enquiries, the querying by the district governor and his associates of who has authorized the work (5:3) and who is undertaking it (5:4) is clearly seen as potentially if not actually obstructive (“they did not stop them”). [...] The Chronicler (2 Chr 7:16) recounts the divine promise to Solomon that his “eyes” will always be at the temple, but in the context of the return from exile, perhaps most relevant of all is God’s word through Jeremiah (24:6): “I will set my eyes on them for good, and I will bring them back to this land. I will build them up, and not tear them down; I will plant them, and not uproot them.” Whether it is God’s “hand” (Ezra 7:6, 9; etc.) or his “eye,” the image of divine attention and tangible support is clear.

5:11 Given that Rehum and others introduce themselves as “servants” of the Persian crown (Artaxerxes) in correspondence from a later period (included, however, already in 4:11), the returnees’ self-identification as “servants of the God of heaven and earth” is a bold beginning. While Cyrus’s edict and the returnees themselves (cf. 5:12) refer to the “God of heaven” (see commentary on 1:2), the allusion to the original construction of the temple by Solomon (“a great king of Israel”) may explain the returnees’ recognition of their God’s sovereignty over not merely heaven but “the earth” as well. After all, the opening verses of Solomon’s prayer of dedication in 1 Kgs 8 (to which Neh 1 is perhaps also indebted) are not only replete with “servant” language, they also consider the question of God’s presence on earth

as it is in heaven. In alluding to Solomon’s earlier building, the returnees yet again underline the continuity of their own building with that of the past.

5:12 The note of continuity is sounded again as the returnees explain the exile in terms of the failings of their “fathers.” The focus on the sins of the previous generation (rather than the present one; cf. Neh 1:5–7) likely reflects the official purpose of the correspondence rather than the lack of contrition or sense of responsibility, given what we see elsewhere among the exiles (cf. Ezek 18). [...] Evidently, for the exiles, God’s sovereignty is to be seen in both the ruin and the restoration. Of course, as we have seen, it is crucial for the exiles that the same people who were “carried” off to Babylon are now doing the rebuilding.

54. David J. Shepherd and Christopher J.H. Wright, *The Two Horizons Old Testament Commentary: Ezra and Nehemiah* (Eerdmans Publishing Co., 2018) 19–20.

Bible Text: Ezra 5 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Ezra 5:3-5

- What painful political reality is behind the question: “Who gave you a decree to build this house?” (In other words, why would this have been an intimidating question?)
- What are some earthly realities and circumstances that remind me of the ways I am limited in my ability to serve God and build his kingdom?
- How does v. 5 give me reassurance regarding how I can move forward with faith and vision in the face of opposition and life constraints?

Ezra 5:11-17

- What can I learn from the way the Jews identified themselves when questioned by the governors of the province Beyond the River?

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Ezra 6 Commentary⁵⁵

6:6–12 Having supplied the requested confirmation of the edict from Cyrus's time, the reply of Darius now further obliges by providing the current king's directives to the governors: "keep away" (6:6) being practically explained in terms of noninterference with the building activities of the Jewish leadership (6:7). Darius's confirmation of the crown's renewed or continuing financial support for the rebuilding (6:8) is specified in terms that must have satisfied the returnees and frustrated the governor of "Beyond the River" in equal measure (i.e., "in full," "without delay" from "Beyond the River's" provincial funds). [...] The challenges of interpreting 6:11 make the precise nature of the punishment for altering the decree difficult to determine. While the measures seem draconian by modern standards, they are broadly characteristic of the Persians' approach as it appears in their own documents (Behistun Inscription §67) and Jewish literature (e.g., Dan 2:5; 3:29).

Darius's invocation of the returnees' God and his official recognition of and tangible support for his worship in the final form of the correspondence serve to reaffirm that the divine superintending of Persian power that had begun with Cyrus (1:1) continues under the current regime.

6:13–15 The due execution of Darius's orders ("with all diligence") by Tattenai and his associates leads to a notice of the successful completion of the building (6:14). In the preface to the resumption of the building (5:1–2), the focus is solely on the initiative of the returnees' God and his prophets (Haggai and Zechariah). Here, at its conclusion, pride of place is still given to these same prophets (6:14a) and to the decree of the God of Israel, but now alongside the decree of the Persian kings, including Artaxerxes, whose later involvement (7:15–24, 27) is here likely anticipated.

6:16–18 [...] Now with the temple completed, it is not surprising that the dedication includes both celebration and sacrifice, just as Solomon's dedication of its predecessor did. The emphasis at this point is clear: the priests, Levites, and the rest of the returnees are, as in both Solomon's day and Zerubbabel's (3:1), nothing less than a reconstituted "people of Israel" (6:16) experiencing something of the same joy (6:16; 3:12–13; 1 Kgs 8:66) and offering the requisite sacrifices (Ezra 6:17; 3:3–6; 1 Kgs 8:63; 2 Chr 7:5). While the returning community's "twelve tribes" may be implied in Ezra 2:2, they are fully visible here in the twelve goats offered for the sins of "all Israel" (6:17)—a pattern paralleled precisely by the tribal leaders' dedication of the

altar of the tabernacle in the days of Moses (Num 7).

6:19–22 [...] The insistence too in Ezra that the Passover was celebrated only by those outsiders who had separated themselves from uncleanness (6:21; in keeping with Num 9:14) stands at odds with Hezekiah's practice of relaxing the pertinent regulations (2 Chr 30:17–20). Finally, the specific sequence of the (re)dedication by the tribal leaders (Ezra 6:17; Num 7), purification of the Levites (Ezra 6:20a; Num 8), and celebration of the Passover (Ezra 6:20b–21; Num 9) that appears in both Ezra and Numbers seems unlikely to be accidental.

As in the Passovers of Hezekiah (2 Chr 30:13) and Josiah (35:17), here the Feast of Unleavened Bread follows (see Num 28:17), and as in Hezekiah's time, the emphasis of the report falls on the emotion of the celebration (cf. 2 Chr 30:21). Here, however, alongside the narration of emotion there is explanation: they celebrate "with joy, for YHWH had made them joyful." That this joy is related to what has been accomplished is not syntactically explicit in Ezra 6:22, but is suggested by the reminder in this verse that YHWH had enlisted the royal might of Mesopotamia (lit., a turning of the king's "heart") in completing the restoration of his "house"—a fitting recapitulation of the theme introduced at the outset of the book and visible at various points in the chapters that have followed.

55. David J. Shepherd and Christopher J.H. Wright, *The Two Horizons Old Testament Commentary: Ezra and Nehemiah* (Eerdmans Publishing Co., 2018).

Bible Text: Ezra 6 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Ezra 6:6-12

- Given Tattenai and Shethar-bozenai's letter to Darius was full of concern for the king's interests, what is surprising about Darius's response to them?
- What does this passage reveal about how God works, and how can I apply this when I face obstacles in doing His work?

Ezra 6:16-17

- How did the Israelites find joy in exile after so many years of loss and displacement?

Ezra 6:19-22

- What identity would have been reinforced or rekindled in the returned exiles by the celebration of this inaugural Passover?

Scripture Memory: Psalm 32

Please feel free to use the space below to review and memorize the passage.

Ezra 7 Commentary⁵⁶

7:1–6 As with previous lists (cf. Ezra 2), the paramount concern is to establish continuity with the past—extending in this case back to Aaron the chief or first priest of Moses’s time. Irrespective of its provenance, the length of the genealogy requires the narrative to resume by clarifying that it was “this Ezra” (7:6a) who came back from Babylon. Whatever else a “scribe” may be equipped and called upon to do (7:12, 21), the emphasis here in the description of Ezra is on his proficiency in the “Torah of Moses, which YHWH, the God of Israel, had given.” While the text notes that Artaxerxes too is generous (“giving all for which Ezra asked”), it is at pains to clarify that the gift of Persian royal favor and provision derives ultimately from the “hand of YHWH his God which was upon him [i.e., Ezra].”

7:7–10 Ezra joins a relatively small group of texts in the Hebrew Bible where the verb “to seek” is governed by the word of God (Isa 34:16). In 1 Chr 28:8, David charges the leaders of Israel to not merely “observe” but also “seek” the commandments of YHWH your God “that you may possess this good land and leave it for an inheritance to your children after you forever.” The notion that “seeking” then involves more than merely obedience to, but rather deep engagement with, the written word is reinforced by the instructive references found in Ps 119. [...] Ezra’s commitment to a searching enquiry of Torah is accompanied by a conviction (Ezra 7:10) regarding his own practical application of it (“to do” it) and then finally to inculcate this same passion and process within the community through education (“to teach” the statutes and ordinances in Israel).

7:11–20 As conventional as both phrases are for the Persian crown, that the “king of kings” acknowledges the “God of heaven” must have been a significant encouragement for a community of returnees attempting to reconcile the unlimited sovereignty of YHWH with the undeniable precariousness of their position.

7:21–24 That the royal check is not entirely blank and that even Persian largesse has its limits is made clear by what appears to be a separate decree addressed now to provincial treasurers. [...] 7:23 confirms that like Darius (Ezra 6) and Cyrus before him, Artaxerxes’s desire to support the Jewish cult in Yehud (“let it be done with zeal”) stems from a calculated and pragmatic piety that seeks to cultivate loyalty among the elite of the religious establishment and

appease the gods whose “wrath” he fears might otherwise destroy the empire.

7:25–26 That Ezra is equipped to proceed according to the “wisdom of your God, which is in your hand” suggests an equation of “wisdom” with “the law of your God,” which the letter has already specified is also “in your [i.e., Ezra’s] hand” (7:14). [...] That Ezra’s jurisdiction is limited to the Jewish community/ies within the province is suggested by the mention of “all the people . . . who know the laws of your God” (7:25), but the specification of comparable punishments, listed here in descending order of severity, for the violation of this law and “the law of the king” (7:26), is an indication of both the significance of Ezra’s authority and the importance of his role in educating the local communities (7:25: “you shall teach”).

7:27–28 The first words of Ezra himself encountered in the book that bears his name offer a blessing of YHWH of the sort found in the Psalms (e.g., 28:6; 31:21) and indeed elsewhere on the lips of Israel’s past leaders (e.g., 1 Kgs 8:15). Like Jehoshaphat in 2 Chr 20:6 (after his own reformation efforts), Ezra also invokes the “God of our fathers” (Ezra 7:27; elsewhere only Deut 26:7) and recognizes the “hand” of God (Ezra 7:28; cf. 7:6, 9) as the stimulus for his strengthened resolve and invitation to others to “go up” (cf. 7:9) with him to Jerusalem. The specific catalyst for Ezra’s blessing is, first, his conviction that the same God who “turned the heart” of Darius to complete the temple in Jerusalem (6:22), also “placed in the heart” of Artaxerxes the impulse to glorify/beautify it. The second stimulus is his belief that the same “loving-kindness” of God that was celebrated at the completion of the altar in the early days of the return (3:11) has persuaded the Persian king to allow Ezra to play his part in the further restoration of worship in Jerusalem.

56. David J. Shepherd and Christopher J.H. Wright, *The Two Horizons Old Testament Commentary: Ezra and Nehemiah* (Eerdmans Publishing Co., 2018) 21–23.

Bible Text: Ezra 7 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Ezra 7:6-10

- How does Ezra's character relate with God's hand being upon him in this passage?

Ezra 7:10

- What is the relationship between studying, doing, and teaching the Law of the Lord?

Ezra 7:12-26

- Note the reverence King Artaxerxes expresses for the God of Israel and the respect for the priesthood. How does this reveal the impact of Ezra's character, piety, and wisdom, and how can I emulate him?

Ezra 7:27-28

- How did Ezra respond when he realized that the hand of the Lord was on him?

Monday, November 9, 2026

Ezra 8 Commentary⁵⁷

8:15–20 Reporting his review of those assembled, Ezra notes, but does not explain, the initial absence of the Levites (about which one may thus only speculate), but his immediate action to remedy the situation provides advance notice of their importance for his mission. The list of those sent to recruit Levites seems to include a suspicious number of “(El)nathans,” but the importance of the embassy is underlined by Ezra’s sending of those who are “leaders” (8:16) and “those who are wise” (or perhaps “those skilled in instruction”). Nothing is known of Casiphia, nor its leader, Iddo and his brethren, but the nature of the request, “send us ministers for the house of our God” (8:17), and the speedy compliance (8:18) suggest that Casiphia may have been a spiritual center for the exilic community (or at least some Levites), though one may only speculate regarding what worship facilities it may have offered.

In keeping with the reduced enrollment generally in the second return, significantly fewer Levites (38) volunteer than in Zerubbabel’s time but their descent from Merari (entrusted with the transport of sacred things; Exod 6:16; Num 3:17) may be relevant given the role that some of them will be asked to fulfill (8:24–30). The temple servants who will return (220) are also reduced in number in comparison with earlier times but are apparently still too numerous to mention by name in the context of Ezra’s memoir (8:20). Whether it is the provision of all of these or Sherebiah alone that is understood to betoken God’s favor, Ezra voices his conviction that the Levitical addition to the traveling party is a sign that the specifically “good hand of God” (7:9; cf. 7:6, 28: “hand of God” simpliciter) is now resting not on him alone, but also “us.”

8:21–36 As elsewhere in Jewish literature and practice of the postexilic period (10:6; Neh 9:1; Esth 4:3, 16), the offering of prayer is enhanced by fasting (Ezra 8:21, 23)—a tangible expression of the community’s humble hope for the “straight/smooth road” through the wilderness envisioned in Isa 40:3. Having proclaimed the fast (Ezra 8:21), Ezra then reports not only the community’s prayer, but the divine protection afforded—visible of course only from the vantage point of the journey’s end (8:31–32), but reported here to emphasize the efficacy of the community’s petitionary faith.

Ezra’s setting apart of twelve priests (8:24; cf. 2:2; 6:17; 8:3–13) is not likely to be accidental (though here all are members of a single tribe), nor is his listing of the donors

and the careful accounting of their contributions (8:25–27); by doing these things Ezra celebrates yet again the support of the crown and the community for the worship of YHWH. In emphasizing that both the Levites and their freight are “holy” (8:28), Ezra acknowledges the appropriateness of the descendants of Merari for the transportation of the sacred vessels. It is precisely because these and “the silver and gold” are for “YHWH, the God of your fathers” (8:28) that Ezra provides clear instructions to ensure that they arrive safely, not merely in Jerusalem, but “within the rooms of the house of YHWH” (8:29; cf. Neh 10:37–39; 13:4–9). Ezra’s issuing of orders to “guard” and to “weigh” the treasure out on arrival will have been intended to protect both the precious goods against thievery and the porters (and Ezra himself) against any suggestion of personal profit or mismanagement.

In the record of the burnt offerings made on their arrival, the recurring appearance of twelve (“bulls for all Israel” and “male goats” as a sin offering) and its multiple (ninety-six rams) strikes that same chord of continuity with the distant past (Num 7) as was struck more recently in connection with the restoration of the temple (Ezra 6:17).

57. David J. Shepherd and Christopher J.H. Wright, *The Two Horizons Old Testament Commentary: Ezra and Nehemiah* (Eerdmans Publishing Co., 2018) 24–25.

Bible Text: Ezra 4 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Ezra 8:15-20

- Why is the lack of Levites among those returning such a sad and significant detail in light of Artaxerxes's decree in chapter 7?
- Consider what the multiple conversations in this passage might have been like, including talk of the issues and stakes involved. Why is Sherebiah's decision so significant and beautiful?

Ezra 8:24-34

- Why did they go through such care to ensure that “the whole was counted and weighed, and the weight of everything was recorded”?
- What does this reveal about Ezra’s character?

Tuesday, November 10, 2026

Handwriting practice lines consisting of 20 horizontal dotted lines.

Ezra 9 Commentary⁵⁸

9:1–2 The problem voiced by the chiefs (9:1a) relates to the intermarriage of Israelites, including primarily or initially some of their fellow chiefs (9:2b) with the “peoples of the land” (9:2). That such a practice represents “faithlessness/sin” (9:2) in their own eyes is explained by their association of the “peoples of the land” (i.e., those who were not identified with the returnees) with the abominations of a list of nations that is generally familiar from the Pentateuch (e.g., Gen 15:19–20; Exod 3:8). The tradition assumed here seems to be drawing upon a combination of Deut 7:1–3, which proscribes intermarriage with the usual seven nations indigenous to Canaan, and Deut 23:2–7 which excludes from the community Edomites and Egyptians up to the third generation and Ammonites and Moabites altogether.

9:3–5 If he had offered instruction on the passages of which the chiefs seem to be aware, but was himself -unaware of the scale or existence of the problem, Ezra’s dramatic reaction here may well be intended to suggest the strength of his own personal shock and dismay. If, however, as is perhaps more likely, Ezra was already specifically aware of the problem, the strength of Ezra’s response here will be primarily for the benefit of galvanizing the community into the appropriate response.

Much like the term “Quakers” of the more recent past, “all who trembled at the words of the God of Israel” (Ezra 9:4; Isa 66:2, 5) evidently became a way of referring to a party within the returnees distinguished by their particular reverence for and interpretation of the Torah (Ezra 10:3). Their sympathies may well have been wholly or partly prompted by Ezra’s ministry, but their solidarity with him is unmistakably expressed here by their sitting “appalled” with Ezra, in much the same manner as Job’s friends do (2:13).

9:6–7 Now that others have expressed their solidarity with him, Ezra commences his confession by identifying with the community’s sin (“our iniquities”) in spite of his own individual innocence. It is precisely because the community’s sins and iniquities have “climbed to the heavens” (9:6) that Ezra is ashamed to “show [lit., lift] his face” (Job 22:26) to the God of the heavens (Ezra 1:2; 5:11–12; 6:9–10; 7:12, 21, 23). [...] Ezra here insists that the sins of his own generation have added height to the tower of trespasses already erected in the preexilic period.

9:8–9 The guilt of Ezra and his contemporaries is all the greater, he admits, because of the grace that the “remnant” (i.e., the community associated with the returnees) has experienced “for a brief moment” (i.e., since the edict of Cyrus). The “givenness” of this grace is expressed in the gift of “a stake” (NRSV; lit., “a tent peg”) in the holy place, which likely intends a contrast to the nomadic transience of exile (see, e.g., Isa 33:20). [...] While Ezra’s prayer acknowledges that the “bondage” (Ezra 9:8–9) of exile is not ended, God’s graciousness is seen in the extension of love to them, such that their Persian overlords (as in 7:28) have in turn allowed them a minirevival (9:8–9) defined in terms of restoring the ruins of the temple and setting up a “wall” in Judea and Jerusalem.

9:10–15 [...] Like the prayers of lament found in the Psalms, Ezra’s prayer displays a profound awareness of the problem in the relationship between God and his people. [...] Ezra’s prayer includes features such as a request for attentiveness, a historical recital/reflection, and rhetorical questions toward its conclusion. Given Ezra’s role and activities as described earlier in his memoir, it is hardly surprising that even when praying, he is also preaching/teaching Torah (primarily as mediated by Deuteronomy).¹

58. David J. Shepherd and Christopher J.H. Wright, *The Two Horizons Old Testament Commentary: Ezra and Nehemiah* (Eerdmans Publishing Co., 2018).

Bible Text: Ezra 9 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Ezra 9:1-2, 10-14

- What was the Israelites' crucial mistake? In what ways have I "not separated [myself] from the peoples of the lands with their abominations"? How is God warning me through this passage?
- What is especially tragic that "in this faithlessness the hand of the officials and chief men has been foremost"?

Ezra 9:13-15

- What does this passage show about the components of genuine repentance, and what posture does it call for when coming into God's presence?

Ezra 10 Commentary⁵⁹

10:1–2 While Ezra’s initial reaction attracts an inner circle of sympathizers who sit in silence (10:3–4), his subsequent—equally emotional—outburst of contrition now draws a large cross-section of the community (“men, women, and children”) to the outer courts of the temple, where the people weep in solidarity with him (10:1). The community’s confession of marrying foreign women is voiced by Shecaniah, one of the sons of Elam from the first return. He himself is not named as an offender (10:18–44), nor would the implication of Jehiel (10:26) necessarily implicate Shecaniah or exclude him from the community, even if this Jehiel was his father (10:2). While echoing Ezra’s corporate confession of the community’s “faithlessness” (so the chiefs in 9:2), Shecaniah also suggests that there may yet be “hope for Israel.”

10:3–4 Shecaniah’s proposed solution is to enter into a “covenant” with God (see, e.g., 2 Chr 15:8–15; 29:10) and to “send away” all the women and their children—terminology that is atypical of Jewish divorce and possibility pejorative (see footnote to commentary on 10:1–2). Only now is it made clear that at some point in the preceding four months, Ezra had evidently pointed the way toward this solution. That this solution is in accordance with the counsel of Ezra and “the (Torah) Tremblers” is thus less surprising than Shecaniah’s insistence that it is also in accordance with “the law.” There is no legal requirement to divorce foreign wives, but if Deut 24’s provision for divorce in case of “something objectional” (24:1–4) is in view here, then the women might be eligible to marry again. If what is in mind is another more specific precedent or injunction instead, then this will be testimony to the evolution of the legal tradition within a particular stream of postexilic Judaism. In either case, while Shecaniah clearly hands the initiative back to Ezra (Ezra 10:4: “it is your task”), his additional encouragement (“we are with you”) suggests that the community’s continuing solidarity will be as important as Ezra’s willingness to “be strong.”

10:10–11 Ezra begins by clarifying the accusation that was already expressed in his prayer, before insisting on a confession that follows the form of “giving thanks/praise” found elsewhere only in Joshua’s exhortation of Achan to confess his sin (Josh 7:19). This further resonance with the exodus/ settlement/ conquest tradition foregrounds the conviction that the returnees’ sin, like Achan’s, has the potential not only to compromise the divine intention to install his people in the land, but also, as Ezra’s

prayer indicates, to undermine the very existence of the community. That praise cannot be disconnected from—and indeed must be intimately connected to—practice is demonstrated by Ezra’s clarification of the requirement that follows from this confession: “do his will”—defined here as the separation from the peoples of the land and, more to the point, in the case at hand, from “the foreign wives.”

10:12–15 Like their forefathers at Sinai (Exod 24:3), the people respond (Ezra 10:12) clearly (“with a loud voice”), decisively (“we must do”), and apparently collectively (“all the assembly”). While they are conscious—and quite reasonably so—of the impracticality of a group so large trying to resolve the problem then and there, their awareness of the seriousness of the situation (“for we have greatly transgressed”) leads them to an alternative proposal. Given that the leaders have been engaged from the beginning (9:1; 10:5), it is not surprising that they are commissioned to form a representative committee to adjudicate the cases of intermarriage brought before them by those concerned, in the company of local authorities who might speak on their behalf. Once completed, it is hoped that the process will be sufficient to assuage the divine wrath that it is assumed will otherwise destroy the community (cf. 8:22; 9:14).

10:18–19 As is common in Ezra, the book here includes a list apropos of the foregoing narrative. Like the list of Ezra’s returnees, this one begins with the priests. Unsurprisingly, it is the sons of the house of Jeshua, listed in the first return (2:36), who are indicted, rather than the Aaronic priests who had only just returned to the province with Ezra. Also unsurprising, given the seriousness of the trespass, is that the sending away of the wives was accompanied by a guilt offering.

10:20–24 The absence of temple servants from the list suggests to some that intermarriage was more prevalent among the upper echelons of the community, where both the temptation and opportunity to secure the societal advantages of such matches may have been greater (cf. 9:2). Alternatively, it may be that the problem among the upper classes was not more prevalent, but simply more relevant to the writer—on the assumption that once the practice was addressed and eliminated among the so-called leaders, the rest of the community would soon follow suit.

59. David J. Shepherd and Christopher J.H. Wright, *The Two Horizons Old Testament Commentary: Ezra and Nehemiah* (Eerdmans Publishing Co., 2018), 27–29.

Bible Text: Ezra 10 (ESV)

Option 1: Questions for Personal Study & Reflection

- What does this passage teach me about God, myself, or human nature?
- How can I apply lessons from this passage to my life?

Option 2: Questions to Help You Go Deeper

Ezra 10:1-2

- How does this passage show the impact one person's response to sin can have in helping others see a situation rightly, and how does this challenge me as I live out my Christian identity?
- What does Shecaniah's statement, "But even now there is hope for Israel in spite of this," reveal about their understanding of God?

Ezra 10:18-19

- What lessons can I learn from the men of Jeshua about the proper response to sin? How am I challenged about my response to sin?

Ezra 10:23

- What warning can I take from the fact that even the Levites, who were appointed as God's priests, were guilty of intermarrying foreign women?

Scripture Memory: Psalm 32

Please feel free to use the space below to review and memorize the passage.